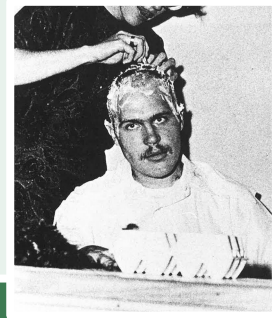
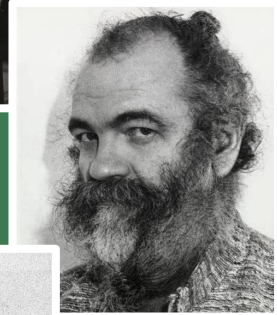


Generating Silence

Session Outline

Today we will:

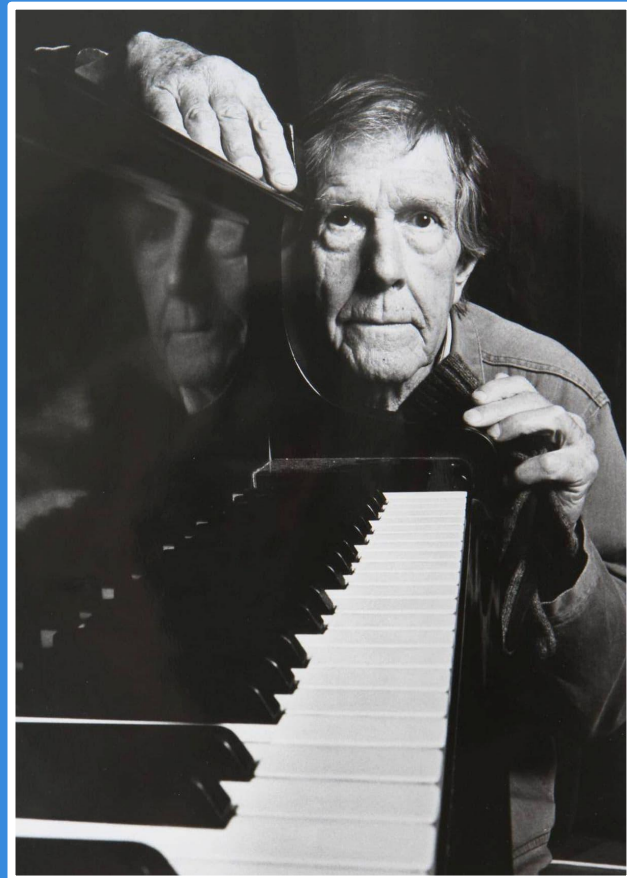
- Discuss John Cage and Silence
- Explore La Monte Young through his event scores
- Sort through Danger Music event scores
- Learn about the assignment
- Practice some composition



John Cage

John Cage (1912-1992) was an American composer, artist, and writer, and one of the most influential figures in 20th century experimental music. His work challenged fundamental assumptions about sound, silence, notation, and the role of the composer.

Between 1956 and 1960 he taught at the New School for Social Research in New York. Students in those classes included George Brecht, Allan Kaprow, and Dick Higgins, all of whom became central figures in the Fluxus movement.



4'33", John Cage (1952/1953)



[A performance by William Marx of John Cage's 4'33.](#)

[Filmed at McCallum Theatre, Palm Desert, CA.](#)

Class Discussion

Is there such a thing as silence?

Even if I get away from people, do I still have to listen to something?

Say I'm off in the woods, do I have to listen to a stream babbling?

Is there always something to hear, never any peace and quiet?

If my head is full of harmony, melody, and rhythm, what happens to
me when the telephone rings, to my piece and quiet, I mean?

And if it was European harmony, melody, and rhythm in my head, what has happened
to the history of, say, Javanese music, with respect, that is to say, to my head?

Are we getting anywhere asking questions?

Note. From Silence: Lectures and Writings (p. 42), by J. Cage, 1961, Wesleyan University Press.

What is this piece asking of a performer?

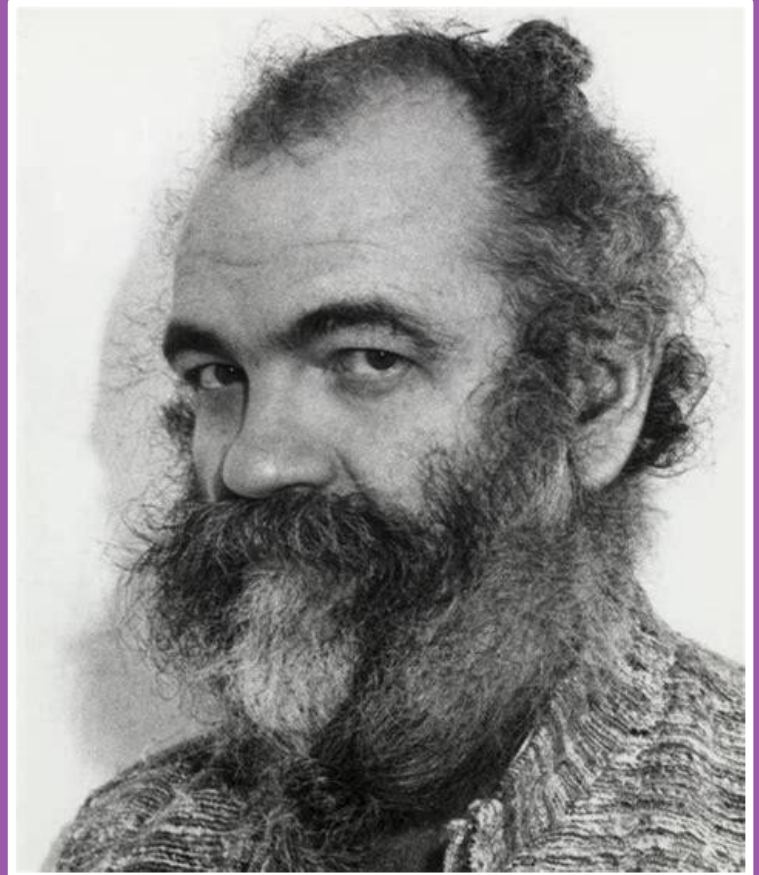
Could anyone perform this?

How would you perform this?

La Monte Young

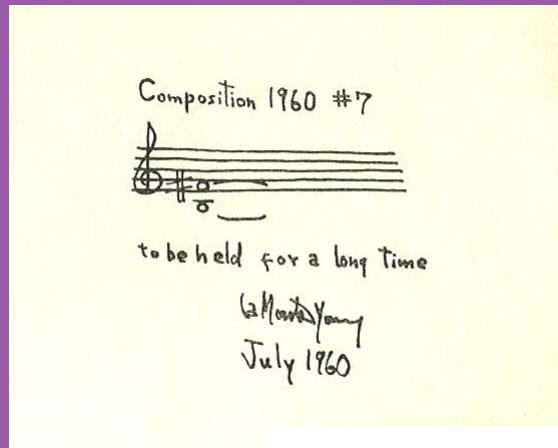
La Monte Young (born 1935) is an American composer widely credited as the first minimalist composer and a foundational figure in the **Fluxus** movement.

Young arrived in New York in 1960, moving directly into the experimental scene shaped by Cage and the New School. That year he organised a concert series at Yoko Ono's loft on Chambers Street, a catalyst for the formation of Fluxus, and produced his *Compositions 1960*, a series of fourteen text-based **event scores** that extended Cage's ideas about indeterminacy into the territory of conceptual art.



Young's Event Scores Activity (A)

- An event score will appear on screen.
- Write the title in the left column and notes on the right
- Write anything that comes to mind: what you'd do, what you notice, what confuses you
- Turn to the person next to you and compare notes. You'll do this for each composition as it appears.



Name: _____

Activity (A)

Event Score Title	Notes

How would you perform this?

Composition 1960 #17



to be held for a long time

(2 Mark) Yang
July 1960

How would you perform this?

Composition 1960 #5

Turn a butterfly (or any number of butterflies) loose in the performance area.

When the composition is over, be sure to allow the butterfly to fly away outside.

The composition may be any length, but if an unlimited amount of time is available, the doors and windows may be opened before the butterfly is turned loose and the composition may be considered finished when the butterfly flies away.

La Monte Young
6.8.60

How would you perform this?

Piano Piece for David Tudor #2

Open the keyboard cover without making, from the operation, any sound that is audible to you.

Try as many times as you like.

The piece is over either when you succeed or when you decide to stop trying. It is not

necessary to explain to the audience. Simply do what you do and, when the piece is over, indicate it in a customary way.

October 1960

How would you perform this?

Composition 1960 #10
to Bob Morris

Draw a straight line
and follow it.

October 1960

How would you perform this?

Composition 1960 # 9

**La Monte Young
October 1960**

**the enclosed score is right side
up when the line is horizontal
and slightly above center**



How would you perform this?

Composition 1960 #15
to Richard Huelsenbeck

This piece is little whirlpools
out in the middle of the ocean.

9:05 A.M.

December 25, 1960

How would you perform this?

Piano Piece for David Tudor #1

Bring a bale of hay and a bucket of water onto the stage for the piano to eat and drink. The performer may then feed the piano or leave it to eat by itself. If the former, the piece is over after the piano has been fed. If the latter, it is over after the piano eats or decides not to.

October 1960

How would you perform this?

Composition 1960 #2

Build a fire in front of the audience. Preferably, use wood although other combustibles may be used as necessary for starting the fire or controlling the kind of smoke. The fire may be of any size, but it should not be the kind which is associated with another object, such as a candle or a cigarette lighter. The lights may be turned out.

After the fire is burning, the builder(s) may sit by and watch it for the duration of the composition; however, he(they) should not sit between the fire and the audience in order that its members will be able to see and enjoy the fire.

The composition may be of any duration.

In the event that the performance is broadcast, the microphone may be brought up close to the fire.

5 · 5 · 60

Class Discussion

Often I hear somebody say that the most important thing about a work of art is not that it be new but that it be good. But if we define good as what we like, which is the only definition of good I find useful when discussing art, and then say that we are interested in what is good, it seems to me that we will always be interested in the same things (that is, the same things that we already like).

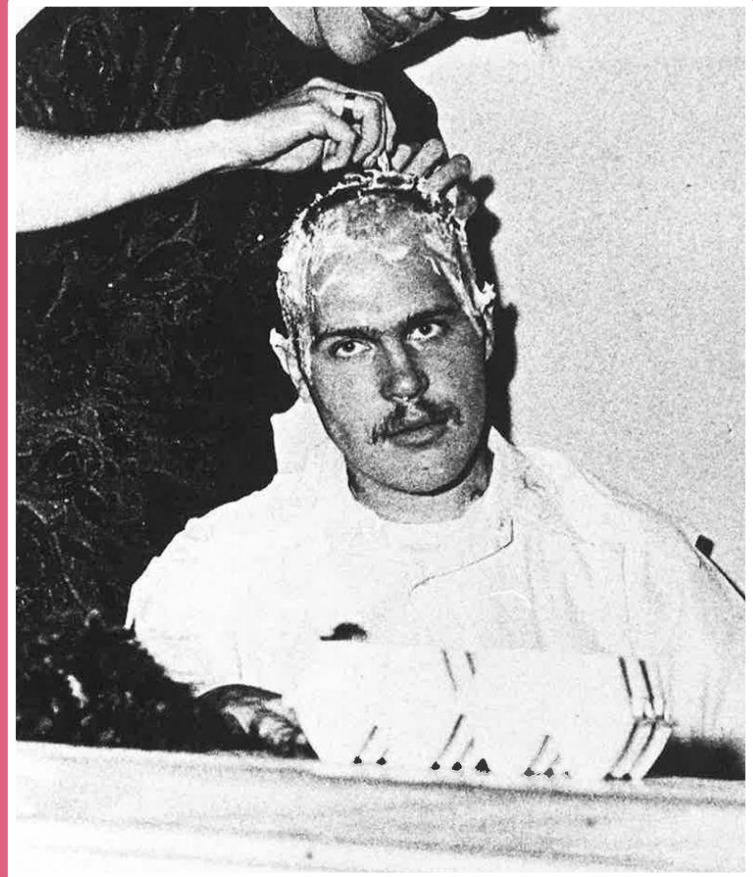
I am not interested in good; I am interested in new—even if this includes the possibility of its being evil.

Note. From "Lecture 1960" (p. 75), by L. M. Young, 1965, The Tulane Drama Review, 10(2), 73–83.

Dick Higgins

Dick Higgins (1938–1998) was an American composer, artist, writer, and publisher. He studied composition under John Cage at the New School for Social Research in New York between 1958 and 1959.

Higgins was a founding member of **Fluxus**, participating in the earliest **Fluxus** events in Europe in 1962. His series *Danger Music* is a set of event scores that push the boundaries of performance, instruction, and risk into deliberately uncomfortable territory.



Higgins' Danger Music Activity (B)

- Spread the cards on the table
- Sorting them into groups
- Use paper markers to name each group
- You can rename categories, split them, merge them, or start fresh
- Content Warning: Some event score will be quite graphic and confronting

Danger Music Number One

Spontaneously catch hold of a hoist hook and be raised up at least three stories. (April 1961)

Danger Music Number Two

Hat. Rags. Paper. Heave. Shave. (May 1961)

Danger Music Number Three

Divide a large pack of incense among those present in a moderately large room. Ask each person to burn his incense, without flame, all together. Darkness throughout. (July 1961)

Danger Music Number Four

$28 + 23 = 51$. (October 20th, 1961)

Danger Music Number Five

Danger Music Number Five is by Nam June Paik. (February 1962)

Class Discussion

When you influence yourself in order to match your self-image, what becomes of your freedom? Which is more crucial to your inner life?

Can a work be its own symbol?

Note. From 13 Serious Considerations, by D. Higgins, 1979, Estate of Dick Higgins.
<https://dickhiggins.org/13-serious-considerations>

Part 1 Assessment Info

Task

- Create an event score and explain your reasoning for your choices
- Ground your intent in at least one work or concept from the experimental tradition covered in class, the reading list or other external Fluxus literature
- You may adapt an existing score from the tradition, or develop your own from the work completed in Session 1

Full Assessment overview on the LMS!

Key materials

- Your worksheet from Session 1
- Session 1 slides and compositions
- Academic reading list on Cage, Young, Higgins and the Fluxus movement

Composition 1960 #17



to be held for a long time

La Monte Young
July 1960

Danger Music Number One

Spontaneously catch hold of a hoist hook and be raised up at least three stories. (April 1961)

Creating Your Event Scores

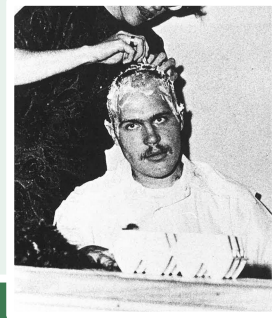
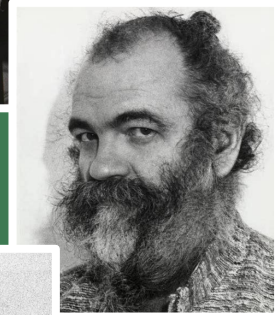
- Write your event scores in the boxes
- Use the space around each box for notes
- Try to fill at least 3
- Don't think too much or too little

Activity (C)	

Session Recap

Today we looked at:

- John Cage at his impact on Fluxus
- La Monte Young's abstract extensions
- Dick Higgin's boundary pushing
- Part 1 of the assignment
- How to create your own event score



Session 2 Preview

In the next session we will:

- Learn how to prompt AI to perform your event score
- Practice in groups
- Reflect on the impact of AI mediated practices
- Learn more about the assignment